

The Exceptional Series of Lie Groups II

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Translator's note. This is a direct English working translation from the project TeX transcription. Mathematical notation and numbering have been kept close to the source.

Abstract. Numerology of exceptional Lie groups and their representations.

As in [1] and [2], we consider in this Note the groups G of the exceptional series

$$e, A_1, A_2, G_2, D_4, F_4, E_6, E_7, E_8.$$

Between the trivial group and A_1 we also insert the supergroup $\mathrm{SOSp}(1, 2)$. More than the group itself, what interests us each time is its category of representations. For $\mathrm{SOSp}(1, 2)$, we consider the category of super-representations for which the parity is given by $-1 \in \mathrm{Sp}(2) \subset \mathrm{SOSp}(1, 2)$. The neutral component G^0 of each group is the adjoint group, and in each case the category of representations under consideration is tensor-generated by the adjoint representation.

The dual Coxeter number $h^\vee$ of G^0 is, according to type,

$$6/5, 3/2, 2, 3, 4, 6, 9, 12, 18, 30.$$

For the trivial group, $h^\vee = 6/5$ by fiat. We regard G as depending on the parameter $h^\vee$. Sometimes it is more convenient to use $\mu := 6/h^\vee$, which we now prefer to the parameter λ used in [1] and [2]:

$$\mu = 5, 4, 3, 2, 3/2, 1, 2/3, 1/2, 1/3, 1/5.$$

For G^0 of rank r , consider the following dominant weights $\theta_1, \dots, \theta_r$. For E_8 we stop at θ_7 . Notation: $(a_1, \dots, a_r)$ denotes $\sum a_i \theta_i$, the fundamental weights ω_i being taken in the order of the Bourbaki tables. For G^0 of rank at least 1, that is, $G \neq e$, θ_1 is the highest root, corresponding to the adjoint representation. This defines the θ_i for G of rank at most 1, namely $G^0 = e$, $\mathrm{SOSp}(1, 2)$, or A_1 . After that, we take

$$A_2: (1, 1), (0, 3);$$

$$G_2: (0, 1), (3, 0);$$

$$D_4: (0, 1, 0, 0), (1, 0, 1, 1), (2, 0, 0, 0), (2, 0, 2, 0);$$

$$F_4: (1, 0, 0, 0), (0, 1, 0, 0), (0, 0, 0, 2), (0, 0, 2, 0);$$

$$E_6: (0, 1, 0, 0, 0, 0), (0, 0, 0, 1, 0, 0), (1, 0, 0, 0, 0, 1), (0, 0, 1, 0, 1, 0), (0, 0, 0, 0, 1, 1), (1, 0, 0, 0, 2, 0);$$

$$E_7: \text{ the fundamental weights } \omega_1, \omega_3, \omega_6, \omega_4, \text{ and } (0, 1, 0, 0, 0, 0, 1), (0, 1, 0, 0, 1, 0, 0), (0, 0, 0, 0, 1, 0, 1);$$

$$E_8: \text{ the fundamental weights } \omega_8, \omega_7, \omega_1, \omega_6, \omega_2, \omega_5, \omega_3.$$

For A_2 , D_4 , and E_6 , it would be immaterial to replace these θ_i by their images under a common automorphism of the Dynkin diagram.

When G is connected, we write $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_r)$ for the irreducible representation of G of dominant weight $\sum p_i \theta_i$. When G is disconnected, this weight must be decorated, as in [1], in order to define $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_r)$. The required decoration is as follows. For A_1 : the sign $(-1)^{p_1}$ if $p_2 = 0$, and 0 otherwise. For D_4 : $+$, $0+$, or $0-$. For E_8 : $+$ or $0-$.

Let V_i be the representation $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_r)$ for $p_i = \delta_i^j$. The representation V_1 , defined for G of rank at least 1, is the adjoint representation. The representations V_i ($1 \leq i \leq 7$) are the representations $\mathcal{J}$, $\mathcal{X}_2$, $\mathcal{Y}_2^*$, $\mathcal{X}_3$, $\mathcal{O}^*$, $\mathcal{X}_4$, $\mathcal{F}^*$ of [1]. The representation $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_r)$ is characterized by the properties that it has dominant weight $\sum p_i \theta_i$ and is a constituent of the tensor product of the $V_i^{\otimes p_i}$.

For $s \leq r$, we will also write $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_s)$ for $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_s, 0, \dots, 0)$.

Our purpose is to describe, for fixed $p_1, \dots, p_7$, similarities among the representations $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_s)$ of the groups in the exceptional series of rank at least s . The analogue in the series A is this: given a decreasing sequence of integers $\ell_1 \geq \ell_2 \geq \dots \geq \ell_k \geq 0$, take the corresponding representation of $\mathrm{GL}(n)$ for each $n \geq k$.

Let G be a simple split pinned group, let $\mathfrak{g}$ be its Lie algebra, and let $\mathfrak{h}$ be the Lie algebra of the pinned split torus T . Identify the group of weights $X := \mathrm{Hom}(T, \mathbb{G}_m)$ with a subgroup of the dual $\mathfrak{h}^\vee$. The canonical bilinear form $(\ , \)$ is the bilinear form on $\mathfrak{h}^\vee$ inverse to the Killing form $\mathrm{Tr}(\mathrm{ad} x \cdot \mathrm{ad} y)$ on $\mathfrak{h}$. For a classical supergroup, for instance $\mathrm{SOSp}(1, 2)$, use the supertrace. If α_0 is the highest root, one definition of the dual Coxeter number $h^\vee$ is that

$$(\alpha_0, \alpha_0) = 1/h^\vee.$$

To each dominant weight λ we will attach a finite system of rational numbers, each taken with a multiplicity $m(q) \in \mathbb{Z}$. In other words, we attach a measure $L_G(\lambda)$ on $\mathbb{Q}$, a $\mathbb{Z}$ -linear combination $\sum m(q) \delta[q]$ of Dirac measures. Let $[R^+]$ be the measure on X given by the sum of the Dirac measures $\delta[\alpha]$ for α a positive root. Let $M(\lambda)$ be the measure on $\mathbb{Q}$ which is the image of $[R^+]$ under $(2\lambda, \cdot) : X \rightarrow \mathbb{Q}$. The factor “12” is explained by the integrality assertion in Theorem 1. If all roots have the same length, or if α is a long root, then $(\lambda, \alpha) = \lambda(H_\alpha)/2h^\vee$. If G has roots of two different lengths and α is short, then

$$(\lambda, \alpha) = ((\alpha, \alpha)/(\alpha_0, \alpha_0)) \lambda(H_\alpha)/2h^\vee.$$

The factor $(\alpha, \alpha)/(\alpha_0, \alpha_0)$ is $1/4$, $1/3$, $1/2$ for $\mathrm{SOSp}(1, 2)$, G_2 , and F_4 , respectively. Let ρ be the half-sum $\frac{1}{2} \int \alpha \cdot [R^+]$ of the positive roots. For a classical supergroup, for example $\mathrm{SOSp}(1, 2)$, these definitions should use instead the sum over positive roots $\sum m(\alpha) \delta[\alpha]$, with $m(\alpha) = 1$ if the corresponding root subspace is even and $m(\alpha) = -1$ if it is odd. We define

$$L_G(\lambda) := M(\lambda + \rho) - M(\rho). \quad (1)$$

When no ambiguity can result, we simply write $L(\lambda)$ for $L_G(\lambda)$. If $L(\lambda) = \sum m(q) \delta[q]$, Weyl’s dimension formula says that the representation $V(\lambda)$ of dominant weight λ has dimension

$$\dim V(\lambda) = \prod_q m(q)^{-1}. \quad (2)$$

Let $F_{2N}^{\mathfrak{g}}$ be the function $\mathrm{Tr}((\mathrm{ad} x)^{2N})$ on $\mathfrak{g}$. Restrict it to $\mathfrak{h}$, and identify $\mathfrak{h}$ with $\mathfrak{h}^\vee$ by the canonical bilinear form. We obtain a function $F_{2N}^{\mathfrak{g}}$ on $\mathfrak{h}^\vee$. By construction,

$$F_{2N}^{\mathfrak{g}}(\lambda + \rho) - F_{2N}^{\mathfrak{g}}(\rho) = 2 \cdot 12^{-N} \sum m(q) q^{2N} L_G(\lambda). \quad (3)$$

The factor 2 comes from the fact that the definition of $L_G(\lambda)$ starts from R^+ and not from the set $R = R^+ \cup (-R^+)$ of all roots. Applying Theorem 2, p. 267, of Duflo [3] to the weights λ and

0, one can make explicit an element of the center of the enveloping algebra which acts on $V(\lambda)$ by $F_{2N}^{\mathfrak{g}}(\lambda + \rho) - F_{2N}^{\mathfrak{g}}(\rho)$. For $N = 1$, it is the Casimir.

For $p_1, \dots, p_7 \in \mathbb{N}$, we will construct a formal linear combination $L(p_1, \dots, p_7)$ of elements of the space $\mathcal{L}$ of linear forms $x \mapsto Ax + B$ with integral coefficients. In other words, it is a $\mathbb{Z}$ -linear combination $\sum m(A, B)\delta[Ax + B]$ of Dirac measures on $\mathbb{Q}$. This combination will specialize to the measure $L_G(\sum p_i \theta_i)$ attached to G .

For $N = 1$, that is, for the scalar by which the Casimir acts on $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_7)$, this is even a linear function:

Theorem 1. *With the preceding notation, for arbitrary $p_1, \dots, p_7$, the sum $\sum m(A, B)(Ax + B)^2$ is linear in x ; equivalently,*

$$\sum m(A, B)A^2 = 0. \quad (4)$$

For $r \leq 7$, we write $L(p_1, \dots, p_r)$ for $L(p_1, \dots, p_r, 0, \dots, 0)$ with $7 - r$ final zeroes. Fix $r \leq 7$ and a group G in the exceptional series of rank at least r . To G there corresponds a rational number μ .

Theorem 2. *If $p_1, \dots, p_r \geq 0$, the zero linear form is not in the support of $L(p_1, \dots, p_r)$, and the total mass of the linear forms $Ax + B$ such that $A\mu + B = 0$ is zero. The scalar*

$$\sum_{A\mu+B=0} (A\mu + B)m(A, B)$$

is an integer. It is the length of the restriction to G^0 of $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_r)$. According to (2), $\dim \mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_r)$ is therefore the value at μ of the rational function $\prod (Ax + B)^{-m(A, B)}$.

More precisely, if $r \leq \text{rank}(G)$ and $A\mu + B = 0$, the multiplicity $m(A, B)$ of $Ax + B$ in $L(p_1, \dots, p_r)$ is zero except in the following cases. If $G = A_2$ and $p_2 > 0$: 1 for $-2x + 4$ and -1 for $-2x + 2$. If $G = D_4, E_8$ and either $p_3 > 0, p_4 = 0$, or $p_3 = 0, p_4 > 0$: 1 for $-3x + 3$ and -1 for $-x + 1$. If $G = F_4, E_8$ and $p_3, p_4 > 0$: 1 for $-3x + 3$ and $-2x + 2$, and -2 for $-x + 1$. If $G = E_6$ and p_5 or p_6 is > 0 : 1 for $-4x + 2$ and -1 for $-2x + 1$.

The $\mathcal{R}(p_1, \dots, p_7)$ for

$$p_1 + 2p_2 + 2p_3 + 3p_4 + 3p_5 + 3p_6 + 4p_7 \leq 4$$

are the representations $1, \mathcal{J}, \mathcal{A}, \mathcal{C}, \mathcal{O}^*, \mathcal{D}, \mathcal{E}, \mathcal{F}, \mathcal{F}^*, \mathcal{G}, \mathcal{H}, \mathcal{I}, \mathcal{J}, \mathcal{X}_i$ ($i \leq 4$), $\mathcal{Y}_i$ ($i \leq 4$), and $\mathcal{Y}_i^*$ of [1], which may be read off from E_7 or E_8 . Thus Theorem 3 recovers part of the dimension formulae of [1].

Let $\mathcal{V}(p_1, \dots, p_7)$ be the convolution

$$\mathcal{V}(p_1, \dots, p_7) := L(p_1, \dots, p_7) * (\delta[x] - \delta[x - 1]). \quad (5)$$

If $L(p_1, \dots, p_7) = \sum m(A, B)\delta[Ax + B]$ and $\mathcal{V}(p_1, \dots, p_7) = \sum n(A, B)\delta[Ax + B]$, then the finitely supported functions $m(A, B)$ and $n(A, B)$ determine one another by

$$n(A, B) = m(A, B) - m(A + 1, B), \quad (6)$$

$$m(A, B) = \sum_{A' \geq A} n(A', B). \quad (7)$$

In (10), the sum is over A' ; the factor $(A' \geq A)$ is 1 if $A' \geq A$ and 0 otherwise.

We will take (10) as the definition of $L(p_1, \dots, p_7)$, with $\mathcal{V}(p_1, \dots, p_7)$ defined by specialization from a $\mathbb{Z}$ -linear combination $\mathbf{V}$ of Dirac measures on the space of maps from $\mathbb{Z}^7$ to $\mathbb{Q}$ of the form

$$(B; n; a_1, \dots, a_7) \mapsto \left(2 \sum a_i p_i + n\right)x + B. \quad (8)$$

The measure $\mathbf{V}$ has a simple description in terms of the root system of type E_8 .

Write $(B; n; a_1, \dots, a_7)$ for the function (11), write $\delta[B; n; a_1, \dots, a_7]$ for the Dirac measure supported at this function, and write $\{\varepsilon_1, \dots, \varepsilon_8\}$ for the root $2\delta - \alpha_3$ of E_8 . With this notation, $\mathbf{V}$ is defined as follows.

(A) Each positive root $\{c, e, g, h, f, d, b, a\}$ fixed by s_4 contributes to $\mathbf{V}$

$$\delta[B + h + n - 1; a, b, c, d, e, f, g] - \delta[B + h; n - 1; a, b, c, d, e, f, g]$$

with $5h + n = a + b + c + d + e + f + g + h$.

(B) Each pair of positive roots $\{c, e, g, h', f, d, b, a\}$, $\{c, e, g, h'', f, d, b, a\}$ interchanged by s_4 , with $h'' < h'$ —then $h'' = h' - 1$ —contributes to $\mathbf{V}$

$$\delta[B + h' + n' - 1; a, b, c, d, e, f, g] - \delta[B + h''; n'' - 1; a, b, c, d, e, f, g]$$

with $5h' + n' = a + b + c + d + e + f + g + h'$ and $5h'' + n'' = a + b + c + d + e + f + g + h''$.

(C) $\mathbf{V}$ is the sum of these contributions and of the $\mathbb{Z}$ -linear combination of the $\delta[B; n; 0, \dots, 0]$ such that, for every B and n , the total mass of the $(B; n; a_i, \dots)$ is zero.

Definition 3. (i) $\mathcal{V}(p_1, \dots, p_7)$ is the image of $\mathbf{V}$ under evaluation at $(p_1, \dots, p_7)$:

$$(B; n; a_1, \dots, a_7) \mapsto \left(2 \sum a_i p_i + n\right) x + B \in \mathbb{Q}.$$

(ii) It follows from (C) above that, for each B_0 , the mass in $\mathcal{V}(p_1, \dots, p_7)$ of the $Ax + B$ with $B = B_0$ is zero. Define $L(p_1, \dots, p_7)$ by (8), i.e. by (10).

It is immediate from the definition of $\mathbf{V}$ that

Proposition 4. (i) *On the support of $\mathbf{V}$, one has $B \in \mathbb{Z}$ and $n \geq 0$.*

(ii) *The projections of $\mathbf{V}$ by*

$$(a) \ (B; n; a_1, \dots, a_7) \mapsto (B; n) \in \mathbb{Z}^2,$$

$$(b) \ (B; n; a_1, \dots, a_7) \mapsto (a_1, \dots, a_7) \in \mathbb{Z}^7,$$

are zero.

The vanishing (ii a) is equivalent to $\mathcal{V}(0, \dots, 0) = 0$, i.e. to $L(0, \dots, 0) = 0$. This is compatible with the fact that $\mathcal{R}(0, \dots, 0)$ is, for every G , the trivial representation of dominant weight 0, and that $L_G(0) = 0$.

Taking account of (1) and of the fact that the total mass of $\mathbf{V}$ is zero, the vanishing (ii b) is equivalent to the following statement: for every N , as a function of $p_1, \dots, p_7$,

$$\sum \left(2 \sum a_i p_i + B\right)^{2N} L(p_1, \dots, p_7)$$

has degree at most $2N$. This is compatible, through (4), with the fact that for every simple Lie group G , $F_{2N}^g(\lambda)$ is a function of degree at most $2N$ in the weight λ .

Put $\Lambda = 2 \sum a_i \theta_i + \rho$. Theorem 2 can be reformulated as

$$\int_{\Lambda} (\Lambda + x - 1)(\Lambda + 1) \cdot \mathbf{V} = 0, \tag{9}$$

identically in the indeterminates p_i .

Some indications on the proof of Theorem 1. — Let G be a group of the exceptional series and put $r = \inf(\text{rank}(G), 7)$. Except for E_8 and the simple root α_4 , no positive root is

orthogonal to all the θ_i ($1 \leq i \leq r$). Put $[R^G] := [R^+]$ if $G \neq E_8$, and $[R^G] = [R^+] - \delta[\alpha_4]$ if $G = E_8$. Define the moving part of $L_G(\sum p_i \theta_i)$ by

$$L_G^{\text{mob}}\left(\sum p_i \theta_i\right) = \left\langle M\left(\sum p_i \theta_i + \rho\right), [R^G] \right\rangle. \quad (10)$$

The definition (1) rewrites as $L_G(\sum p_i \theta_i) = L_G^{\text{mob}}(\sum p_i \theta_i) - L_G^{\text{mob}}(0)$.

Theorem 1 for G uses of $\mathbf{V}$ only its image $\mathbf{V}_G$ under

$$(B; n; a_1, \dots, a_r) \mapsto \left(2 \sum a_i p_i + n + B; a_1, \dots, a_r\right). \quad (11)$$

Decompose $\mathbf{V}_G$ as $\mathbf{V}_G^+ - \mathbf{V}_G^-$, the moving part $\mathbf{V}_G^+$, respectively the fixed part $\mathbf{V}_G^-$, having support where $(a_1, \dots, a_r) \neq 0$, respectively $= 0$. Theorem 1 follows from its analogue for the moving parts of L and $\mathbf{V}$: by Proposition 1 (ii a), the fixed part is recovered by putting $x = 0$. For $(a_1, \dots, a_r) \neq 0$, let $R^{(a_1, \dots, a_r)}$ be the set of positive roots α such that $(\alpha, \theta_i) = a_i$ for $1 \leq i \leq r$. The form $(\ , \)$ is as in (5)–(6). For $G \neq E_8$, each $R^{(a_1, \dots, a_r)}$ is a singleton or empty, and their union is R^+ . For $G = E_8$, each $R^{(a_1, \dots, a_r)}$ is an orbit of $\{s_3, s_4\}$ or is empty. Their union is $R^+ - \{\alpha_4\}$. Let $\mathbf{V}_G^{(a_1, \dots, a_r)}$ be the measure on $\mathbb{Q}$ which is the inverse image of $\mathbf{V}_G$ by $q \mapsto (Bh^\vee/6 + n; a_1, \dots, a_r)$: the mass of q is the mass of the $(B; n; a_1, \dots, a_r, \dots)$ with $Bh^\vee/6 + n = q$. Let $[R^{(a_1, \dots, a_r)}]$ be the sum of the $\delta[\alpha]$ for $\alpha \in R^{(a_1, \dots, a_r)}$. Theorem 1, for the moving parts of L and $\mathbf{V}$, decomposes as the sum of the equalities

$$(p_i \cdot [R^{(a_1, \dots, a_r)}]) * (\delta[0] - \delta[-1]) = \mathbf{V}_G^{(a_1, \dots, a_r)}. \quad (12)$$

Our proof of (15) is by brute force. Below are a few properties of the root systems involved which may help explain what is happening.

When all roots have the same length, $(\lambda, \alpha) = \lambda(H_\alpha)$ and (ρ, α) is the sum of the coefficients of α expressed as a linear combination of simple roots. For E_8 , $(\rho, \alpha) = 5$, and (15) follows immediately from the definition of $\mathbf{V}$.

Let R be the root system of type A_1 , A_2 , D_4 , E_6 , or E_7 , and let r be its rank. In the root system of type E_8 , the fundamental weights $\theta_1, \dots, \theta_r$ correspond to simple roots $\alpha_{S(1)}, \dots, \alpha_{S(r)}$. Let S_1 be the complementary set of $8 - r$ simple roots, and let W' be the Weyl group generated by the corresponding reflections. Let $\langle \theta_1, \dots, \theta_r \rangle$ be the vector space spanned by $\theta_1, \dots, \theta_r$. Other descriptions: it is the orthogonal of $\langle \theta_i \mid i \in S_1 \rangle$, or the fixed subspace of W' . One checks case by case that the roots of E_8 lying in $\langle \theta_1, \dots, \theta_r \rangle$ form a root system of type R , and that, if one takes as positive roots of this root system those that are positive for E_8 , the fundamental weights of E_8 are the dominant weights $\theta_1, \dots, \theta_r$ of R .

For R of one of the indicated types, (15) follows from the following assertions, which we verified for D_4 , F_4 , and E_7 :

(a) Let T be an orbit of W' in the set of roots of E_8 . If T is not reduced to a fixed point and, for $t \in T$, (t, θ_i) —constant on T —is > 0 for some θ_i ($1 \leq i \leq r$), then the contribution of T to $\mathbf{V}$ has zero image under (14).

(b) Let ρ_R and $h_R^\vee$ denote the sum of the fundamental weights and the dual Coxeter number of R . If α lies in $\langle \theta_1, \dots, \theta_r \rangle$ and is a positive root, necessarily fixed by s_4 , then, with the notation of part (A) of the definition of $\mathbf{V}$, one has

$$(h^\vee/6)(\rho_R, \alpha) + n = (\rho, \alpha).$$

Examples. — Verify (a) for E_7 . The orbit T is here a pair of roots as in part (B) of the definition of $\mathbf{V}$. The point is to verify that $3h' + n' \geq 3h'' + n'' - 1$. Indeed, $h'' = h' - 1$ and $4h' + n' = 4h'' + n''$, i.e. $n'' = n' + 4$.

Theorem 1 gives the dependence on G of $F_{2N}^g(\lambda + \rho) - F_{2N}^g(\rho)$ for certain λ .

Proposition 5. For $1 \leq N \leq 8$, $F_{2N}(\rho)$ is, as a function of G , a function of $\mu = 6/h^\vee$ of the form $P_{2N}(\mu)/\mu(\mu+1)$, for a polynomial $P_{2N}(X)$ of degree $2N$ satisfying $P_{2N}(X) = P_{2N}(-1-X)$.

It follows from Duflo [3] that $F_{2N}(\rho)$ is the value for G , in the sense of [5], of a linear combination of trivalent graphs with oriented vertices. For $N \leq 3$, arguments imitating [5], 6.8, 6.9, make it possible to deduce the proposition from this presentation of $F_{2N}(\rho)$. Beyond that, we know how to verify it only by brute force. Since we have only ten groups G at our disposal, the proposition remains true, but is empty, for $N \geq 9$.

Correction to [2]. — The formula given for $\dim(\mathcal{X}_4)$ is erroneous. See [1] for the correct formula.

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